

Zero Sum: A Modern Thriller Roleplaying Game

Core Concept

Zero Sum is a tabletop roleplaying game set in the present day (2026). There are no monsters, no magic, and no futuristic tech to save you. The real horrors are systemic: corrupt corporations, unchecked intelligence agencies, black money networks, and ruthless political machines.

The players take on the roles of ordinary people—journalists, whistleblowers, forensic accountants, activists, or disgraced professionals—who have stumbled onto a conspiracy far larger than themselves. They have seen something they shouldn't have, and now, powerful entities want them silenced.

Tone & Atmosphere

- **Perpetual Paranoia:** The protagonists should never feel safe. Their phones might be tapped, their bank accounts can be frozen at any moment, and their loved ones are potential leverage.
- **Asymmetric Conflict:** The enemies have endless resources, legal immunity, and institutional power. The players have their wits, limited resources, and the truth.
- **Lethality:** Combat is not a sport; it's a desperate fight for survival. A single gunshot wound can be fatal or require a trip to an illegal back-alley doctor that compromises their location.
- **Plot Twists:** Trust is a luxury. Allies have ulterior motives, the "good guys" are compromised, and the conspiracy constantly shifts shapes when you think you've figured it out.

Setting the Stage: 2026

The world is teetering on the edge. Economic instability, deepfakes, AI-driven misinformation campaigns, and extreme political polarization have created a powder keg. Against this backdrop, massive shadow organizations manipulate markets, rig elections, and eliminate dissidents without a trace.